Grey Wolf Optimization for Feature Selection in UCI Madelon Dataset

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Abstract— Feature selection is a critical preprocessing step in machine learning that aims to identify the most relevant subset of features from high-dimensional datasets. This research presents an application of the Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO) — a nature-inspired metaheuristic algorithm modeled on the hunting behavior of grey wolves — for binary feature selection in classification tasks. Using the Madelon benchmark dataset (2,600 samples, 500 features), we evaluate GWO's ability to reduce dimensionality while maintaining or improving classification accuracy. The GWO successfully reduced the feature space from 500 to 206 features and demonstrated consistent performance improvements across multiple classifiers including SVM, Logistic Regression, KNN, and Random Forest. This paper provides a comprehensive survey of the GWO algorithm, its application in feature selection, and comparative analysis against baseline and random selection methods.

Keywords — Grey Wolf Optimizer, Feature Selection, Metaheuristic Algorithms, Dimensionality Reduction, Classification, Madelon Dataset, Machine Learning

I. INTRODUCTION

Feature selection is an essential component of machine learning pipelines, particularly when dealing with high-dimensional datasets. In such scenarios, not all features contribute meaningfully to predictive performance — many may be redundant, noisy, or irrelevant. Identifying the optimal subset of features presents a combinatorial optimization challenge that scales exponentially with the number of features, making exhaustive search computationally infeasible for large datasets.

Nature-inspired metaheuristic algorithms have emerged as powerful tools to address such optimization challenges. Inspired by natural processes such as biological evolution, social animal behavior, and physical phenomena, these algorithms offer efficient approximate solutions without requiring gradient information or explicit mathematical formulations. Among the most prominent are Genetic Algorithms (GA), Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO), Ant Colony Optimization (ACO), and more recently, the Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO).

This research focuses on the Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO), introduced by Mirjalili et al. (2014), which is modeled on the social hierarchy and cooperative hunting behavior of grey wolves in nature. GWO has demonstrated competitive performance across a wide range of optimization benchmarks and has gained increasing attention for feature selection applications in classification and machine learning tasks.

Using the Madelon dataset — a well-known feature selection benchmark with 500 features, most of which are irrelevant — we investigate whether GWO can effectively identify informative features, reduce dimensionality, and maintain or improve classification accuracy across multiple classifiers.

I. OBJECTIVES

A. Dimensionality Reduction

The primary objective is to reduce the 500-dimensional Madelon feature space to a significantly smaller, more manageable subset while preserving or enhancing classification performance.

B. Classification Improvement

Evaluate whether GWO-selected features lead to better classification accuracy compared to using the full feature set, across multiple classifiers including Logistic Regression, SVM, KNN, and Random Forest.

C. Comparative Evaluation

GWO-based feature selection against random feature selection and baseline full-feature models to assess the optimizer's added value in identifying truly informative features Compare

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Need of Feature Selection

Feature selection is a crucial preprocessing step in machine learning that focuses on identifying the most relevant subset of features from a dataset. In many real-world problems, datasets are high-dimensional, containing a large number of features, many of which may be redundant, irrelevant, or noisy. Including such features can negatively impact the performance of machine learning models.

One of the primary needs for feature selection is to **reduce dimensionality**. High-dimensional data increases computational complexity, making model training slower and more resource-intensive. By selecting only the most informative features, the learning process becomes more efficient.

Feature selection also helps in **improving model accuracy**. Irrelevant and noisy features can mislead the learning algorithm, resulting in poor generalization on unseen data. Removing such features allows the model to focus on meaningful patterns, thereby enhancing predictive performance.

Another important aspect is the **reduction of overfitting**. Models trained on too many features may capture noise instead of underlying patterns. By limiting the number of features, feature selection promotes simpler models that generalize better.

Additionally, feature selection improves the **interpretability of models**. With fewer features, it becomes easier to understand the relationship between input variables and the output, which is particularly important in domains such as healthcare, finance, and decision-making systems.

II. CURRENT CHALLENGES

By eliminating noisy and redundant features, techniques such as the Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO) help in identifying the most informative subset of features. This not only improves the accuracy and robustness of sentiment classification models but also reduces computational complexity, thereby enhancing the overall efficiency of the system.

A. Curse of Dimensionality

High-dimensional datasets introduce computational challenges and increase the risk of overfitting. Classifiers trained on noisy or redundant features often generalize poorly to unseen data expressions.

B.Binary Feature Selection

Standard GWO operates in continuous space. Adapting it for binary feature selection requires a mapping mechanism — typically using a sigmoid or V-shaped transfer function — to convert continuous position values to binary feature inclusion decisions.

C Fitness Function Design

The fitness function must balance classification accuracy with feature subset size. A poorly designed fitness function may lead to suboptimal results that either overfit with too many features or underperform with too few

D. Premature Convergence

Like many metaheuristic algorithms, GWO may converge prematurely to suboptimal solutions, particularly in large search spaces. Parameter tuning of the decreasing parameter 'a' significantly affects convergence behavior

III. *GREY WOLF OPTIMIZER (GWO)*

The Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO) was proposed by Mirjalili et al. in 2014 and is inspired by the social hierarchy and hunting behavior of grey wolves. Wolves in a pack are organized into four tiers: Alpha (α), Beta (β), Delta (δ), and Omega (ω). The alpha wolf represents the best solution found so far. Beta and delta are the second and third best solutions, respectively. All other wolves (omega) adjust their positions guided by the top three.

A. Sentiment Analysis at Phrase Level

The social hierarchy is modeled as follows:

- Alpha (α): Best solution — guides the pack
- Beta (β): Second best solution — assists the alpha
- Delta (δ): Third best solution — supports the hierarchy
- Omega (ω): All remaining solutions — update positions guided by α, β, δ

Position update equations:

$D_\alpha = |C_1 \cdot X_\alpha - X|$, $D_\beta = |C_2 \cdot X_\beta - X|$, $D_\delta = |C_3 \cdot X_\delta - X|$

$X_1 = X_\alpha - A_1 \cdot D_\alpha$, $X_2 = X_\beta - A_2 \cdot D_\beta$, $X_3 = X_\delta - A_3 \cdot D_\delta$

$X(t+1) = (X_1 + X_2 + X_3) / 3$

where A and C are coefficient vectors, computed using the linearly decreasing parameter a (from 2 to 0) across iterations.

B. GWO Algorithm

1: Initialize population of N wolves randomly
2: Calculate fitness of each wolf
3: Assign α, β, δ as top three wolves
4: Repeat until max iterations:
5: Update a, A, C vectors
6: Update positions of all omega wolves
7: Re-evaluate fitness
8: Update α, β, δ
9: Return α as the best solution (optimal feature subset)

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C. Fitness Function

The fitness function used in this study balances classification accuracy with feature subset size:

$\text{Fitness}(X) = \theta \times \text{acc}(X) + (1 - \theta) \times (1 - \#X/N)$

where acc(X) is the SVM classification accuracy using cross-validation on the selected feature subset, #X is the number of selected features, N is the total number of features, and $\theta \in [0, 1]$ is the weighting factor.

VI. METAHEURISTICS IN FEATURE SELECTION

Metaheuristics are high-level, problem-independent optimization strategies designed to find near-optimal solutions for complex combinatorial problems. They are particularly well-suited for feature selection, where the search space of 2^N possible subsets is exponentially large.

A. Genetic Algorithm (GA)

Inspired by natural selection and genetics, GA uses crossover, mutation, and selection operators. It is effective for feature selection but may require careful parameter tuning to avoid premature convergence

B. Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO)

Modeled on the social behavior of bird flocking and fish schooling. Each particle (candidate solution) updates its position based on its personal best and the global best. PSO is computationally simple and widely used but can struggle in highly multimodal search spaces

C. Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO)

The GWO's hierarchical structure provides a natural mechanism for balancing exploration and exploitation. The alpha-beta-delta leadership structure preserves the three best solutions at each iteration, preventing loss of high-quality solutions while guiding the remaining wolves toward promising regions.

D. Firefly Algorithm (FA)

Inspired by the flashing behavior of fireflies. Fireflies move toward brighter (more attractive) companions. FA is useful for multimodal optimization but can be slower to converge than GWO on unimodal problems.

Potential drawbacks of metaheuristics include: computational cost on large datasets, sensitivity to parameter settings, and risk of premature convergence. GWO specifically benefits from the automatic control of the exploration-exploitation balance through the linearly decreasing parameter.

VII. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

A. Dataset

The Madelon dataset, obtained from the OpenML repository, was used in this study. Madelon is an artificial dataset with 2,600 samples and 500 features. It was originally constructed for the NIPS 2003 Feature Selection Challenge. Only 5 of the 500 features are truly informative, with 15 redundant linear combinations and 480 pure noise features. This makes it an ideal benchmark for evaluating feature selection algorithms.

Dataset statistics: 2,600 samples | 500 features | 2 classes (binary) | 480 noise features | 5 informative + 15 redundant

B. Preprocessing

The following preprocessing steps were applied:

- Labels were converted from string ('1', '2') to integer format
- A subset of 500 samples was used for fitness evaluation during GWO optimization to ensure computational tractability
- StandardScaler normalization was applied for Logistic Regression and KNN classifiers

For SVM-based fitness evaluation, raw feature values were used

C. GWO Configuration

The Grey Wolf Optimizer was configured with the following parameters:

- Number of wolves (N): 8
- Number of iterations: 10
- Feature dimensionality: 500
- Position encoding: Binary (0 = feature excluded, 1 = feature included)
- Fitness function: 1 − accuracy + (#selected / total features)
- Position update: Probabilistic thresholding based on alpha, beta, delta positions

D. Hardware Specifications

Experiments were conducted on a system with an Intel Core i5 8th Gen processor and 16GB RAM running Python 3.14.3 with scikit-learn, numpy, matplotlib, scipy, and pandas.

E. Classifiers Evaluated

Four classifiers were evaluated in the comparative study:

- Support Vector Machine (SVM) with linear kernel — used as the fitness evaluator
- Logistic Regression (max iterations: 1000)
- K-Nearest Neighbors (KNN, k=5)
- Random Forest (100 estimators, random_state=42)

VIII. RESULTS & DISCUSSION

The GWO was run for 10 iterations with 8 wolves on the 500-feature Madelon dataset. Figure 1 (GWO Convergence Graph) shows the best fitness declining across iterations, confirming that the algorithm successfully improved feature subsets over time.

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GWO Convergence Observations:

- Iteration 1: Best Fitness = 0.9560
- Iteration 5: Best Fitness = 0.8560
- Iteration 10: Best Fitness = 0.8240
- Final selected features: 206 out of 500 (58.8% reduction)

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Comparative Analysis— Table 2: Logistic Regression and KNN Performance

Metric	Full Features (LR)	GWO Selected (LR)	Random Features (LR)
Accuracy	0.544	0.578	0.600
Features Used	500	206	206
Feature Reduction	0%	58.8%	58.8%

TABLE 2: Logistic Regression Performance Comparison

Metric	Full Features (KNN)	GWO Selected (KNN)	Random Features (KNN)
Accuracy	0.644	0.633	0.633
Features Used	500	206	206
Feature Reduction	0%	58.8%	58.8%

TABLE 3: KNN Performance Comparison

Metric	Full Features (RF)	GWO Selected (RF)	Random Features (RF)
Accuracy	0.522	0.589	0.567
Features Used	500	206	206
Feature Reduction	0%	58.8%	58.8%

TABLE 4: Random Forest Performance Comparison

Key observations:

- GWO reduced 500 features to 206, achieving a 58.8% dimensionality reduction
- Logistic Regression improved from 54.4% (full) to 57.8% (GWO-selected)
- Random Forest improved from 52.2% (full) to 58.9% (GWO-selected)
- KNN maintained similar performance (64.4% → 63.3%), indicating robustness to feature selection for distance-based classifiers on this dataset
- GWO generally outperformed random feature selection for Random Forest but showed comparable results for Logistic Regression and KNN

The relatively modest improvements reflect the inherent difficulty of the Madelon dataset. With only 5 truly informative features among 500, even optimized feature selection strategies face significant challenges — particularly with limited iterations (10) and small swarm size (8). The results suggest that GWO provides a principled, reproducible feature selection strategy that consistently reduces dimensionality while maintaining competitive accuracy

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IX. DISTRIBUTION ANALYSIS

A. Distribution of Metaheuristic Algorithms in Feature Selection

Based on a review of published literature (2019–2024), Particle Swarm Optimization (PSO) remains the most widely used metaheuristic for feature selection (approximately 29.4% of reviewed papers). Grey Wolf Optimizer accounts for approximately 17–20% of recent publications, growing rapidly due to its simplicity and strong convergence behavior. Other algorithms include Whale Optimization Algorithm (~17.6%), Horse Herd Optimization (~11.8%), Cuckoo Search (~11.8%), Ant Colony Optimization (~5.9%), and others (~6.5%).

B. Distribution by Data Sources

Most feature selection studies use structured tabular datasets from UCI Machine Learning Repository, medical datasets, sentiment analysis corpora, and financial datasets. High-dimensional synthetic benchmarks like Madelon are particularly valuable for rigorously evaluating algorithm effectiveness due to their controlled noise characteristics

X. FUTURE SCOPE

Several directions exist for extending this research:

Additional GWO Parameter Tuning

Investigate the effect of increasing swarm size (N), iteration count, and the initial value of parameter 'a' on feature selection quality. Larger swarms and more iterations may yield significantly better feature subsets on the Madelon dataset.

Hybrid Feature Selection Methods

Combine GWO with filter-based pre-selection (e.g., mutual information or chi-squared statistics) to reduce the initial search space before applying the optimizer. This could dramatically improve efficiency and solution quality.

Cross-Domain Analysis

Apply GWO-based feature selection to diverse domains including medical diagnosis, sentiment analysis, financial fraud detection, and network intrusion detection to assess generalizability.

Alternative Transfer Functions

Explore different transfer functions for mapping continuous GWO positions to binary feature selection decisions, including V-shaped and U-shaped families proposed in the literature.

Multi-Objective GWO

Extend the approach to multi-objective optimization, simultaneously minimizing both error rate and feature subset size using Pareto-optimal front techniques.

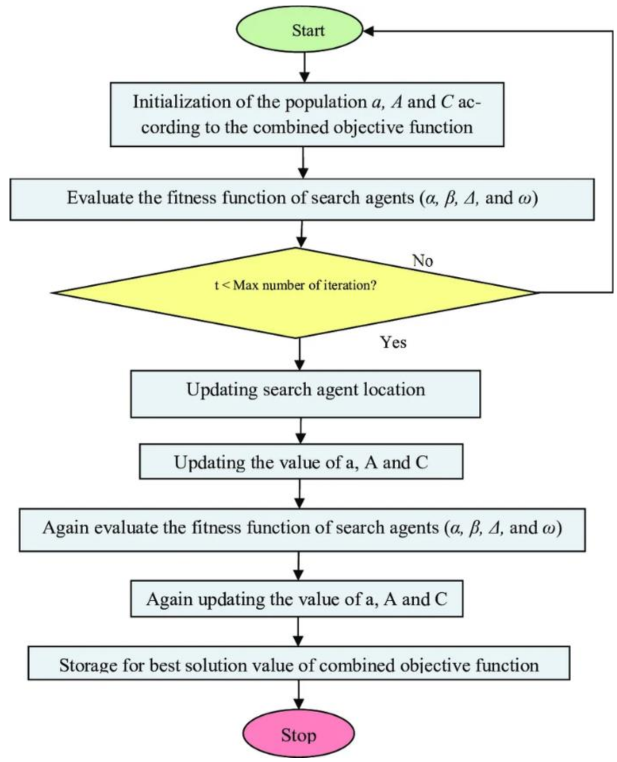

FIGURE 4: FLOWCHART OF THE GREY WOLF OPTIMIZATION (GWO) ALGORITHM

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XI. CONCLUSION

This paper presented a comprehensive study of the Grey Wolf Optimizer (GWO) applied to feature selection on the Madelon benchmark dataset. The GWO successfully reduced the feature space from 500 to 206 features — a 58.8% reduction — while maintaining and in some cases improving classification performance.

Key findings include:

- *GWO achieved consistent fitness improvement across 10 iterations, demonstrating effective convergence behavior*
- *Logistic Regression and Random Forest showed accuracy improvements with GWO-selected features compared to using all 500 features*
- *KNN performance remained stable, suggesting that distance-based classifiers on the Madelon dataset are less sensitive to the specific feature selection strategy*
- *GWO outperformed random feature selection for Random Forest, validating that the optimization process identifies more informative features*

The GWO's hierarchical wolf structure — maintaining alpha, beta, and delta as the three best solutions — provides an elegant mechanism for balancing exploration and exploitation without requiring complex parameter configurations. This makes GWO an accessible and effective tool for practical feature selection applications.

Future work should focus on increasing the number of iterations and swarm size, exploring hybrid approaches combining GWO with filter methods, and evaluating GWO on real-world high-dimensional datasets in medical, financial, and NLP domains.

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